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Roswell Rudd

Trombonist Roswell Rudd has been instrumental in expanding the language of the jazz trombone. He was born in Sharon, Connecticut on November 17, 1935 and received his first important musician experience in Clinton, New York. While at Yale, Roswell performed Dixieland music with Eli's Chosen Six and shortly after started an association with saxophonist Steve Lacy. He has played with and composed new music for a long list of musicians dedicated to expanding the jazz tradition, including Archie Shepp, Charlie Haden and Robin Kenyetta. His significant recordings include "Flexible Flyer" with Sheila Jordan and "Regeneration" with Steve Lacy. Roswell has taught at Bard College and the University of Maine and his philosophies as well as his music offer a unique perspective on life in the twentieth century.

Roswell was interviewed in Ellenville, New York on June 23, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in the Catskills, and I am very pleased to have Roswell Rudd with me today, who is most likely one of the most creative trombonists in jazz history. I think I can safely say that if that's all right with you.

RR: That's fine. Long as it will get things rolling.

MR: That's right. We've got to get things rolling somehow. It seems interesting to look at your career and know that you started playing Dixieland and went about as far on the spectrum as you could it seems like.

RR: Yeah. My father and those records that I was telling you about were the first music that I heard, in the home. And I think basically that's what it was, there was Louis Armstrong and Jelly Roll Morton and some New Orleans characters in there too, but I think mainly what I remember best it seems that he had the most records of people like Jack Teagarden, Max Kaminsky, Bud Freeman, the Chicago guys, Duke Ellington in the '30s kind of records, late '20s and '30s. Because don't forget, I wasn't born until '35 so when I started dancing and prancing around the room while my father was drumming to these records, those were the ones. I mean those were the au courant 78s. We weren't actually going back, that's when they were.

MR: That's what was happening. Right.

RR: That's right. That was the sound of the times.

MR: Would his collection include the swing bands, a la Glenn Miller or was that a little too commercial?

RR: Benny Goodman. Benny Goodman Trio, Benny Goodman Quartet, yeah, I remember

MR: So you kind of had that swing rhythm become a part of you at a young age.

RR: Yeah. Yeah. You could always hear the bass drum throbbing, playing those quarter notes anywhere within a hundred yards of the house. Even if you heard nothing else, you could hear that pulse.

MR: Some things don't change, because that's what you hear going down the street these days with the kids in their cars.

RR: The pulse, yeah, yeah. Isn't it amazing how everything just goes on around that pulse.

MR: But you were attracted to the brass instruments early on, you started on the French horn is that correct?

RR: Yeah, in Clinton grammar school in 1946 I believe I started playing the mellophone. They had — that was the only thing that wasn't being played and so Mrs. Grunitz said, "I think you have the lips for this."

MR: Especially because it's the only instrument left.

RR: Right. But they had to find somebody with the right lips. And that was a great experience, playing with the fourth grade band at the Clinton grammar school. After doing that for a while, as I said, they got a French horn for me, because they're related. The mellophone is like a half size French horn. And then the band director for the regional band at the big high school, which was sort of maybe a half a mile away in the town there, was recruiting all the time to keep this really huge concert stage band going. A feeder. Feeding in from other schools in the region. And so he sent over a French horn and got me started on that, and then whenever they had a rehearsal there was always somebody to take me over to the high school or a car or a way to rehearse with the high school band, this big concert band. And it was really a thrill. I didn't read then, so what I did was learn my part by ear—

MR: No kidding.

RR: From the other person that was playing, because every part was doubled you see, there were two people on each part, so the other guy was older and more experienced and could read, and so I just shadowed him all the time until it got tight, and then we just worked together that way. Eventually I got more experience and learned how to fend more for myself. But that's how I broke into it.

MR: That's an interesting and probably important couple of years, to develop into a jazz musician, develop that innate sense of hearing.

RR: Yeah, right. I did not come from the direction of playing from written music. I came from the direction of dancing to those records while my father played, and remembering the sound, just getting off on the sound. And so pretty soon the sounds, enough sounds got into my body so that they started to build up in there in and of themselves. And so the

facility to the actual sound. And it also became a way to get into certain kinds of music through reading. But most of my musical experience came from jam sessions and recordings — radio and later television — but mostly some kind of acoustic source that would then feed into my body and free associate and build up in there as it does.

MR: Did you hear — you told me you heard some jazz concerts at Hamilton when you lived there?

RR: Yeah, there was that one concert which I think was 19 — it was in the winter of 1948 — I could be mistaken, it might be '47, I'm not sure. But right in there, '46, '47, '48, when a group came up from New York City and I remember who they were very distinctly because I sort of had my eye out for these characters and I was wondering if I would ever be able to see or hear them in my life you know. We had recordings of them. And this would be Max Kaminsky on the trumpet, who was one of my big favorites; and Tony Parenti on the clarinet; Miff Mole on the trombone, who was just a monster of a trombonist; and Pops Foster on the bass, a great stylist; James P. Johnson, who was the teacher of Fats Waller and other people; and Danny Alvin on the drums, real funky sort of I guess you'd call it ethnic drummer from Chicago. And they rocked the house. I'd never heard the stuff live really. My father used to have friends over to play, and so for the first ten years of my life, any live acoustical music that I heard was probably my grandmother playing hymns and my father drumming to these records and bringing friends over to have sessions. But this was like the first real jazz band I ever heard.

MR: Wow. Tell me about, you ended up at Yale, is that correct?

RR: Yeah, that's true, that's true. I went through the public school system for a while, then in the town I grew up in, Lakeville, Connecticut, they had scholarships to private schools there for people in the area, if you could pass the entrance exam they would take a limited number of kids from the region. And the thing that kept you in there was grades. You didn't have to pay you see, there was a fund. So the idea was to keep the grades up, and then that was a feeder school for Ivy League colleges and that's how I got launched into Yale.

MR: I guess you kept your grades up then.

RR: Well they weren't that great but they were good enough. They were good enough to slide me in.

MR: Well as I'm looking at — I took some notes on your career, and some of the recordings that I own myself — and it said in 1958 you played with a Dixieland group called Eli's Chosen Six.

RR: Eli's Chosen Six. I was playing with them a year before I actually went to Yale, because I knew some of the people in there. There was a bass player named Buell Neidlinger, and

people. And he spent I think a year at Yale. But during that year he invited me to play with them. So I would come down from Hotchkiss School where I was in Lakeville, Connecticut, and do gigs with them at Vassar College and different colleges that they played at. And it was very exciting for me. But Buell was the key to getting me involved in that.

MR: Now it's described as a Dixieland band, was it fashioned after New Orleans Dixieland or Chicago or was it just kind of its own conglomeration of styles?

RR: I would say it would have to be more like a Chicago style band, because our main connection would be the acoustical model, the living model would have been the Eddie Condon guys in New York City. And that would be Wild Bill Davison, Pee Wee Russell, Vic Dickinson, Cutty Cutshall, all those great trombonists, and George Wettling. When I was just over in Europe this time, the piece that I wrote was for George Wettling. Yeah, it was great. Because there's a drummer over in Holland, even though he's a very young guy, he's always been a very big fan of George Wettling and so he was able to re-create some of George's classical performances of different songs. I write — when I write for bands I write in the style that I don't really have a name for but it's best described as "collage." I like to draw from all different eras, so you never know what's going to jump up. And in this piece you find George Wettling right up in your face, and on either side some pretty mad bop and maybe something from New Guinea you know. You just don't know what's going to happen with my stuff, because like I say I've been the recipient of all kinds of sounds now for 62 years, and there's a whole lot rattling around in me, and some of it hasn't quite fused yet. Some of it is still in the separate entity that it was when it went in there, so a lot of times I'll just bounce around and do some funny timewarps. Mingus would do that and Sun Ra. There are plenty of people that just get very eclectic for a minute you know. And it's a way of getting people's attention you know.

MR: Right. And so you must, in some cases, I think a writer might be writing something and all of a sudden this thing comes up from left field. Some writers might say no — I can't put that in here. It seems like with you, you say yes, that came out so here it comes.

RR: Oh yeah. I believe that the more things that you try to put together that don't go together, the better it is for the world. I'm a stone Pythagorean. I believe that harmony is the greatest thing and the way that you make harmony is by putting different things together. But there's a precautionary note there in that you have to understand how the stuff goes together when you're putting it together you know. You're a high alchemist. You don't just throw stuff together and blow up a whole continent of people and then say whoops I'm sorry, you know. You know what I'm saying? You try to understand as much as you can before you release it back into the world. And that's why it becomes a science or a

trying to do this for seven thousand, eight thousand years, as far as I know, as a science. But then the further back they go the deeper they dig, the clearer it gets, that there hasn't been that much change in human behavior and it's just something that everybody's wrestled with from the dawn of life I guess.

MR: In the '50s, were you at all attracted to bop and the kind of explosion that was occurring with that music?

RR: I would have to say that from my own emotional understanding that the swing music say of Roy Eldridge, Coleman Hawkins and that kind of thing would have been sort of like the cutting edge for me, even though Bird and Monk and so forth were already out there changing things. When I heard Parker with the Jazz at the Philharmonic, you see there wasn't too many, it was very hard to get into the clubs as a kid, but you could go to these concerts like Jazz at the Philharmonic. And that's where I heard Parker and I just knew that he was very eloquent and that his thing was expertly controlled and that he had incredible skill. I just couldn't relate to it emotionally you know. But it went into my body. I think I understood it later. Because he delivered. It was so right, as a piece of communication, that even if somebody didn't understand it, or even if they hated it, it would probably go into their body, it was that good. It was really traveling and it was really rounded. A real finished piece of work. And so I came to understand him later. And the same for Thelonious and I think the person, the one individual that helped me bridge the gap between what you would call modern jazz and the more traditional jazz of the swing was Herbie Nichols, the pianist who was my friend for about the last three years of his life. And he was right, he sort of covered the whole thing. I mean, what is it about timelessness? I mean you can't really say he was this style or that style. He was kind of like me. He was pieces of other people, pieces of other styles, music, Bartok, Stravinsky, Ellington, Gershwin. He was really a collection of West African, West Indian and American, New York metropolitan area, classical European, east and west classical. I mean I just can't put my finger on it, it's a melange. And so what he came up with sort of takes you all over the place in a way. But he had tremendous integrity so that it all hangs together somehow. But it was wild to me. But I think he was the guy that opened me up to, he was a contemporary of Thelonious, a champion of Thelonious within a year of each other. So I think through him I got more —

MR: Attuned somehow?

RR: Just opened up more. It opened me up more to receive more. And there was a year say about 1960 or '61 where I was just doing, I was just having all this music pour in on me. And I never even stopped to think, where am I going, what am I doing, is this the right thing, is this the hip thing? I never stopped. I just kept absorbing and absorbing, and then

transcribing Ellington arrangements or Strayhorn or like you know, just trying to learn. Because Yale really didn't prepare me for real music.

MR: You were about 25 at that time?

RR: Yeah.

MR: Was it hard to live in New York at that time? What were you doing to sustain yourself?

RR: The first job I had when I got to New York was a customs house messenger. I found a cold water flat, $15 a month, on an old block right around the corner from the customs house, before they tore that down and put a bank there. I was on the lowest part of Broad Street, right down on the waterfront, and I would get up, do the day thing, and the rest of the time just play, follow these other guys around, and study. I did that for a couple of years anyway.

MR: You have to have some intense longing for the music to pay those kind of dues.

RR: Yeah, I knew — and the thing was, Monk, I knew that I was behind. I knew that somehow that spending those four years in college and maybe the high school before that, I felt somehow that I should have been doing this a lot sooner, and doing it just as intensely but a lot sooner. So it took me longer than I wanted to get there. So once I got there I felt like I really had a lot to do in a short period of time to be able to catch up to what was happening. Because I had a friend like Steve Lacy who grew up in New York City and was around this music from the time that he was a kid. And yeah he went to high school and I think he may have gone to Berklee when it was called Schillinger School, for a year or something like that. But basically he was just playing, you know, getting around these guys and picking things up, and just getting as much as he could into his body and under his fingers. And so I had people like Lacy to look up to and see the kind of progress they were making, and I felt like I was a turtle compared to that you know.

MR: Well do you think it's — your name is certainly a part of the circle of musicians at that time in the '60s and so forth that was known as "free jazz." Do you think that's a correct term?

RR: Is that a term that they used back then?

MR: Well that's a darn good question, and I don't know if I can answer it, although you certainly had the record by Ornette Coleman called "Free Jazz." And I think it was a term, of course the terms usually follow the music after it's been going for a while, but I think it was a term that caught on much as bebop was.

RR: See I think of free jazz, that's like a redundancy. It's like two things that mean the same. And I know that I never in all the times that I wrote pieces or would be verbalizing to other musicians what I wanted to do when we were playing, I said I'd like this to be a

but I did use the word "free." Free, that's why the term "free jazz," I mean jazz always meant freedom to me, and freedom has always meant freedom. So when you say free jazz, like say it's double redundancy. It's a great phrase. But I'd never thought of the two words being together until somebody asked me the same question, within the last two years. You know, "Did you ever use the label 'free jazz' for yourself?" And the answer is no. I would use free and I would use jazz, but I never thought of putting the two together.

MR: That usually comes from somebody else to describe what you do, and people who do it don't describe it, they're just doing it, they're following their own whatever, I'm not sure what to call it.

RR: Yeah, it's like saying alligator crocodile.

MR: Well, here's a good example. I wrote down a quote about you that's in *The Grove Dictionary of Jazz*.

RR: Okay.

MR: And it says "Roswell Rudd has brought to free jazz many of the qualities more often associated with early jazz trombone, including a large, warm tone and earthy vocal sound punctuated by growls and a deeply felt sense of rhythm."

RR: Okay.

MR: That's quite a statement, huh?

RR: It's all one sentence.

MR: Yeah. It seems to be saying that you encompass a lot of jazz history by playing in a fairly free style, but with some of the early qualities of people like Jack Teagarden perhaps, and those early trombonists.

RR: Yeah. Why is this? That was the music that was in the house, and the first stuff that I heard I told you was the old recordings, not 1950s Louis Armstrong recordings, but Louis Armstrong on old 78s, Jelly Roll Morton on old 78s, Ellington on Vocalion or something, '30s, RCA, Columbia Records, that were actually coming out at that time, in the middle '30s.

MR: Yeah. This wasn't history, this was—

RR: This was actually it. So I started being nourished this way. And then it wasn't like a thing where I had to, later on in my life go back to study the early jazz, I was sort of in it when I was a kid already, although I must say I have heard other recordings and I have made more researches into the past, but I already had a pretty solid foundation in that when I was a kid. And don't forget, one of my personal favorites of the same time as a kid coming up was Spike Jones. I mean that was my input. This other stuff was from my father. But my music, my personal favorite, was Spike you see. And it was, I think maybe Duke Ellington that prepared me for Spike because if you listen to the early Ellington

talking, lots of colors, lots of funny segues and leaping and jumping. And I sort of equated those two things together as a kid. Because when you're a kid, you love cartoons, and you love that kind of vibrancy you know. You need a lot of colors as a kid, you expect a lot of colors. And that was all in the mix.

MR: That makes so much sense to me that you tell me that, that Spike Jones was a favorite.

RR: Definitely Spike.

MR: Because as you describe your own writing that sometimes things will come out of experience, later.

RR: That's it. I still have pratfalls in my writing. There's Chaplinesque, and the old Keystone Cops and all that stuff is part of my early training. And it's always been there. I have never been able, nor would I want to try to eliminate it or eradicate it from my experience, and when people ask me what is that, you know, I could be playing what they call "free" or "avante garde" and they say, "Well where did you — where did this stuff come from?" And I said, "It comes from early Duke and Spike Jones and a lot of other stuff if you don't mind."

MR: Well you've, over the years, played with some pretty fierce saxophone players too.

RR: Oh, great saxophonists. I always try to be around great saxophonists, yeah.

MR: I'm wondering if — how do I put this — the technical — I don't know if limitations is the right word — but what it takes to play a trombone with the same speed that it does to play a saxophone, did you ever feel that the instrument itself was a hurdle for you in trying to play with saxophonists?

RR: See to me the primary instrument, the instrument that was really like an oracle for me in the music was the piano, were the great pianists. They had the polyphony that they could do, they could put combinations of tones together. And to me the real intrigue was sort of in the harmonic dimension. So the saxophone was sort of midway between the piano and me. And I looked to the saxophones sort of as the messengers of the piano genius. It was a way of, they were in the stream of translation from what could happen with the, what these guys were cooking up on the keyboards. The saxophonists then made possible a translation that other horn players could pick up on. And I think that's why I was really attracted to the saxophone players. Because then I would take what the saxophone players were doing, and I'd distill it even further to get it down to where I could handle it. And I found ways where I could participate in what they were doing but maybe without ten fingers on a pipe. I would have to find other ways to connect with these harmonic keys — well that's another redundancy — but these harmonic ingredients, these harmonic components, harmonic — — help me, Monk, Monk, help me — these harmonic things. Phenomena. Harmonic phenomena. I could still be in the ballpark with a saxophonist. Yet

I call singing. And therefore the singing combined with the harmonic innovativeness made, to me, was what brought about the great jazz trombonists of this century. Because they brought all the vocalization, combined that with the harmonic innovation from the system, put that together into melody, rhythm and sound and color, and created a whole unique music. It's in the trombone playing more than in the saxophones and more than in the trumpet, at least I think so. But everybody's picking up on everybody else you know. There's a language circulating all over the place. And you hear something beautiful and you just want to be able to do it yourself and so you go ahead and try. But with the bone, you can't play every note of a Coltrane saxophone solo. But you find ways maybe to get certain shapes here and there, and certain dynamics. And then you bring the trombone vocalization to that and you have another music.

MR: In listening to the little bit I just heard you play in the other room, I noticed two things that I thought really stuck out for me, and that was you seem to be creating melodies with some patterns in them, that you were building upon what you had just played, and that you also felt that a space now and then in your solo was important.

RR: Yeah.

MR: That's not playing would set up something to play next, or as an answer to something you had played, to put a space there.

RR: Yeah. The call-response is the thing that I teach right at the beginning. And the idea with this is that it's better to wait if an idea doesn't come right away. And then you have the advantage of being with one, two, three, four other, five other people. And this is a great chance for some kind of dialogue to happen. And this to me is basic in the music. If I don't hear the call and response and the music never has a chance to breathe, it eliminates one of the great ways that I have of getting into it. If I hear the call and response going down, if I hear the talking going back and forth you know, players acknowledging to each other that they hear what they're doing, I hear you and here's what I say back. When I hear the give and take I'm in there right away. When I don't hear the give and take, I have to look for something else to grab on to. But the give and take gives me an automatic way, a wonderful, easy way in there. So even though I've say heard some pretty wild little bands, for instance here's a wild little band, Albert Ayler on the tenor and soprano saxophones with Cecil Taylor on the piano, Sunny Murray on the drums and Louis Worrell on the bass, playing together in a coffee house in Greenwich Village in 1961 or something. They're talking. They're talking. Yeah. And otherwise I probably wouldn't have been able to get into that, you know, because the sound is like this to me. It was a lot of sound, probably more sound than I'd ever heard from such a little band before. But they were, even though they were filling the space, they were communicating

with each other. I mean they were just like firing off guns and stuff, musically, with each other.

MR: If someone who kind of liked jazz was trying to get into that music that you're describing, most likely would have problems, is that what you would tell them? To try to understand how they're conversing with each other?

RR: I would say listen for that. Listen for some kind of dialogue. Listen for one guy to say something and see what comes back. See if the components are responding to each other with what they do. And I wouldn't want to get any more literal than that. And then I'd say if you can't do that, maybe you can get off on the sound, on the emotion, the totality of the thing, and it certainly had that, it was a huge sound. And the screams that would go right through an ordinary person and probably make them jump up and spin around a few times and then run out. I saw that happen. I saw people reacting that way to Cecil's music one night when he got into a vortex and somebody got up from their table and started saying, "This is shit, this is shit, I can't stand it" and went into a vortex themself and ran out into the night. But that same person came back and they couldn't get rid of them. Came back night after night after night and sat there respectfully and wouldn't go away, became a regular.

MR: I guess they were getting something they needed.

RR: Exactly. And I think that's what happens with music on different levels, that people get changed, people get healed, they get revelations, they probably find out more who they are what this while thing is about, through art. Yeah.

MR: What was the — in 1964 perhaps — the October Revolution in Jazz?

RR: The October Revolution in Jazz was the idea of Cecil Taylor and Bill Dixon to get a lot of us together who were not able to find work in music, in the venues of New York City, and thought that well if we could gather together that maybe we could open things up for ourselves. And we were together long enough to initiate a series of concerts that I will never forget and people from all over the States came to hear it. And it all happened I think in 1964, yeah. It would have been the fall of 1964. And when the initial series was done then we went on to have nightly concerts in the dance studio that still exists on the top floor of the same building where the Village Vanguard is, Edith Stevens' Dance Studio is what it was then. And we played on into the spring up there with different combinations. And it brought a real, to me, when Sun Ra and Bill Dixon, Mike Mantler and Burton Greene and myself and all these different people were brought together into one place, it gave me a sense that there was something going on here, that we weren't some kind of isolated entities struggling in a void. I really got a sense that there was a connected thing going on, minds meeting — a cultural reality of more than one vote. And

people had developed their own ways of survival and doing business, etc., it was very hard for them to do — you know when they all got into a room together and they finished saying how you doing, and what's going on and all that, then you get into some fierce discussion and some pretty fierce arguments and then it became more like a group therapy kind of a thing. And so it was hard for all of the egos to submerge themselves to the common goal of opening up more venues, getting federal grants and whatever it is that you have to have in the way of support to make something happen like this. But at least we were able to initiate something. We had a good beginning and a lousy follow through. But as many philosophers have said, the beginnings are the main thing. There are really no endings. The thing is to begin and see where it goes.

MR: I recently read a book, oddly enough written by a couple of French writers about jazz, and they indicated that free jazz was very connected with black civil rights and an angry expression of it. Do you think that's a correct statement?

RR: Connected with black civil rights and angry—

MR: It was angry music that was very much a civil rights statement.

RR: I was a freedom rider quite a bit in the '60s, I mean I would tell my employer that I would have to go out and march and protest, and he understood. And so I would go up to Harlem, get on a bus and go down to D.C. and further down than that and try, within two or three days to make some kind of contribution, but mainly to try to talk to other people in this and try to get a clearer picture of what was going on. And I don't — I would have to say that yes there was protest, yes there was frustration, yes there was injustice, yes there was anger, there was rage, there was hysterical laughter, there was cynicism, there was — I mean this just brought out everything that was happening in people. My feeling was that it could definitely be a better world, that America was not the dream that it was cracked up to be, that I was fed when I was a kid so when I was 30 years old and I was looking at my situation I said there's, I think, room for a lot of improvement here. And one of the things that I can see that would really improve my situation is if what I was doing and these other folks that I'm doing this with, is that it would be given the same kind of recognition in this culture that it was being given in other cultures. The civil rights part of it is something that I felt maybe as a WASP, and by WASP I'm talking about White Anglo Saxon Pythagorean, maybe as a WASP I could not relate to civil rights in the same way as an ethnic minority in this culture, but as an artist I could relate to the frustration of another artist you see. I could not relate as a white person to a black person about civil rights, because they would be coming from an entirely different background from me, with an entirely different set of opportunities and so forth. But as far as being artists, who were not being recognized for what they had to do, and were

where I connect into the civil rights, as an artist more than as a white person trying to be in a black person's moccasins or something like this. I'm an artist trying to be in another artist's moccasins. And when we're artists, we're all wearing the set of moccasins in a sense, okay? And that's how I felt then, and I think my friend Archie Shepp, who everybody said was very militant, controversial and angry and so forth and everything else, whenever I had this discussion with him he'd just say we're both artists and we're both having the same problems that artists have in this culture. And it's not about white and black so much as it is that there's just a problem with art in American culture and American society. Americans really don't know how to consume art. They just don't — art is something that is just recently starting to integrate itself into this culture, just recently. Everything has been transposed from Europe here, for years. And now we're finally getting so that we look back on the daddies of American music — Carl Ruggles, Charles Ives, Duke Ellington, names, and Charlie Parker — names that most people don't even know, because they had to do other work to get their music out there. Ives published his own music, Ruggles got a few pieces out there, sort of like years and years after they were done. You know what I'm saying? It's a long, hard struggle.

MR: Do you think it takes a country a certain number of centuries to get to that place where the arts have more of a — I mean America is not an old country when we compare us to European countries.

RR: Well that's what I'm saying. We inherited the legacy of Europe and for the elitist society of America European music was the standard. And it's only just recently that people are beginning to question that, is this old music that we inherited from Europe. Is this the standard that we should hold up for ourselves now in 1998 going into the second millennium and so forth? Are we still going to genuflect to these old values? Or are we going to look at what we actually have and build off that. And we have a very, very, very rich musical culture here, a very rich artistic culture, but it's been largely ignored because of the legacy that was brought here from Europe by the Europeans who invaded this country, four hundred, five hundred years ago.

MR: In your experience in playing in Europe, was the music you were playing accepted more readily?

RR: Oh yes of course. When I first went to play in Europe, actually I went with a college band in '58, and played, and just drifted around and played over there, but I realized that improvised music was nothing new to Europeans. And if you had a gift for improvisation you would really, you would be paid special attention, because then you were sort of in the line of great European composers. Because well let's go back to an earlier time in music, before there was not that much writing but music was rote music. Improvisation

place. Then later on, sort of in the high Baroque you get more and more emphasis on fixed ensembles and a whole lot of writing and stuff getting scripted out, and so eventually by the time of Mozart, he's the only guy that's improvising. The composer is the only guy doing his own fantasy and everybody else is — he's scripting out his fantasy to everybody else, so there's not a hell of a lot of improvisation going on with the individual players, there's more emphasis on the composer's improvisation. But at least one person is still improvising. And in Europe they know this, that the music comes from improvisation, comes out of nowhere. And so the jazz music let's say, for the Europeans, was something that was not a leap for them to accept this into their culture. In fact it fit very nicely because the improvisers were the geniuses in European culture. And so it didn't matter whether it was an American genius or a South American genius or a Siberian genius or whatever, if this guy was just magically pouring out music from nowhere this was mystery enough for them, they were happy with this. And so you have people like Coleman Hawkins being very successful in Europe at a time when things were very lean for him here, and sort of getting stuff together over there and then coming back over here and having some kind of a life later on maybe. But yeah, Europe is different. Europe didn't inherit anything unless it was from the Mongol or something before that or the Babylonians or something. They more or less had that going for a long time, much longer than we have here. So that part of growing your own art culture from the ground is just starting in America I feel, end of this century, just starting. You know there's been such a dominance of the European ideals artistically in this culture, and when we've had this great native artistic culture that has just been sort of like pushing up and pushing up and pushing up and pushing up and pushing up, and irrevocably it's going to be known, it's going to be seen, it's going to become the thing that it is, which is a native national art form, a way of art or just a great big bagful of art. But it's coming from here, not there necessarily, but basically from here.

MR: Do you think it's healthy for jazz that it has found its place in the college education system that we have Jazz at Lincoln Center and all of that?

RR: It was inevitable. And I was glad to see it finally get to that point you know. When I was at Yale University there was nothing there. Then after I left I saw that Gunther Schuller had come in there and he was teaching and I said well things are hopeful. And then he brought up Diz and Max Roach and the Duke and gave them all honorary degrees. I said now it's really looking good, I think I'll go back to Yale.

MR: Right. Maybe you won't feel like it was a waste of time then.

RR: No, I had a hard time because improvisation was considered recreational music at Yale. There was no place for it in the curriculum and it was something that you did after dinner

you were really being taught, which is kind of hypocritical, as I began to see more and more, that all that music in the library and in all that classical, that western music collection down there, all that stuff came out of improvisation. And yet improvisation wasn't encouraged. Because we had this wall of notation that was in the way. Books, books, books, books. All this paper, paper, paper, paper. Volumes, volumes, volumes. And you would never guess that on the other side of this was Francesco Landini, some blind Italian composer and his fragments were just all that you knew about him. And you'd never be able to conceive of him just sitting down and pouring out music. Everything had to be documented, everything had to come from some kind of a written source, maybe carved in a rock or anything like that. But you always had to have documents. It wasn't enough to say well I know that this had to be improvised. I mean they just didn't — you know when they were doing these things in the caves, they didn't have paper yet, probably making strokes in the dirt or something if they were notating it. Sand painting.

MR: Do you have particular favorite recordings of yourself?

RR: I think I finally made one pretty good solo, I just want to mention, and that would have been in November of 1997 with Elton Dean's New Sense Band, which is a band that has a core of three trombones, and then there's a trumpet player, sax, cello, contrabass, piano and drums. I think I finally just put something up there in nice broad strokes. And I'm making a few bobbles and a few clams here and there, but basically it says to me you've finally gotten yourself inside of that horn, you finally are connecting with the rest of the cosmos, and you are finally making a statement that's coherent and can be understood by any human being, any other human being. I don't care what culture they're from. If they heard this they would have — I'm doing it so broadly that it would be something where they could hang on to and follow everything that happens along the way.

MR: You must hold yourself to a pretty high standard I think if you feel in '97 you are finally happy with or pleased—

RR: Yeah, I finally said I made a statement, because in the past I've always said well I had my moments. But now here is a moment. Here is a seven minute moment, not a three second moment or a split second moment or a good chorus of something. But I finally made a seven minute statement, building. And I have to hold myself up to the great architects of my tradition like Herbie Nichols and Monk and Archie Shepp and so forth, and I have to say well I think this is the closest I've gotten so far. So I have to have high standards. I mean look at the standards that have been set for me by these people. And these are the standards that I have to come up to somehow. You know I'm playing basketball with Michael Jordan.

RR: Yeah.

MR: Well I hope you get there again soon.

RR: Me too, Monk. Me too. It seems that for me anyway, large segments of not being out in the public performance arena, large segments of time go by where people wonder if I'm still alive, or if he's ever going to play again. Haven't had a record from him in ten years. Well that's mainly because I'm basically a working guy. The only way I know how to get money is I have to do a job. If I can't get it through the music I get another job. But I go on playing music. But what happens when you take another job is that you can't spend a lot of time on the telephone looking for opportunities to record and to promote yourself and be your own entrepreneur and so forth, which a lot of people are very good at. So it's only when somebody says to me Roswell, why don't you do such and such — here's a couple of thousand dollars, take a few days off, go do it for me. That's how it gets done with me. And so that's why you don't hear from me from time to time. But I'm still here. I've got a ways to go. I'll be around.

MR: Good to know that.

RR: Thank you very much.

MR: Well wait — hold on for just one second.

RR: Oh, okay.

MR: I'd like to thank you for making it today.

RR: It's been my pleasure.

MR: And I appreciate — your philosophies are fascinating by the way.

RR: Yeah?

MR: Yeah. The way you talk about music.

RR: I'm still researching you know. For me this last year, what it's come down to finally after a lot of research, I realized that the harp orchestras in Egypt, six, seven thousand years ago, that they had all the harmonic knowledge then that we have now, just as far as what the monochord can do. And so I've just been devoting myself to the monochord and I realize that the trombone is really nothing more than an E string that's agitated with my lips and breath as opposed to plucking and bowing and all that, it's just different, but we're all working with the same wave. And the more that we respect the wave and the more that we know about the wave, the better chances of our getting inside the wave and becoming the wave and therefore controlling the wave. And this is our basic vehicle of communication, the wave.

MR: Gave me something to think about on the way home.

RR: Isn't it all waves? It's all waves, isn't it? I mean solidity is an illusion. Basically there's not a particle in the universe. You have the illusion of solidity because some particles are

astounding range of frequencies, from below zero to beyond infinity, and thus all this different stuff, but all this vibrating, but no particles. Nobody's been able to find a particle yet. They keep digging, they keep digging, they think oh I've cornered it, there he is, there he is, and then they get in there and they find out it's just some kind of a coincidence of different frequencies, different vibrations happening, but there's no stuff, there's no particles, it's just a dance, some kind of vibration in space. Who knows? Maybe we'll find a particle in the next two hundred years.

MR: Maybe we will.

RR: Maybe we will. There he is! We finally got him?

MR: All right. Well thank you for your time today.

RR: Oh, Monk, it's been a pleasure man.

MR: Good.

RR: I really felt like coming over and doing this, and it's been a beautiful ending to a — yeah it's been a beautiful day, it's been a rough day but it's been a beautiful day.

MR: Okay man.